

The Lovely and the Liminal

Year-theme connection: Some journeys do not matter because they end. They matter because of the threshold they pass through.

Opening thought: Liminal spaces are not just empty hallways in online mood boards. They are places, stages, and identities between named states.

Central question: Why can in-between spaces feel unsettling, beautiful, or strangely free?

Main idea in one sentence: The liminal is where categories loosen before a new form settles.

Map of the guide

The big route of the section

Chapter 1 - What in-between really means

Chapter 2 - Architecture built for passing through

Chapter 3 - The uncanny ordinary

Chapter 4 - Rites, thresholds, and unstable identities

Chapter 5 - Why the liminal can be lovely

Final synthesis

The big route of the section

This section is about thresholds, but it refuses to make them only scary. The liminal can be unsettling, empty, beautiful, awkward, sacred, or strangely calm.

Architecture, online aesthetics, rites of passage, and identity thresholds all show places or states where normal categories loosen. A hallway is not a destination. A waiting room is not home. Adolescence is not childhood or adulthood. That in-between can feel exposed.

The key is not to treat liminal as a filter or vibe. It is a serious idea about transition: what happens while one identity, place, or system is no longer stable and the next one has not settled.

Reference to catch: liminality comes from threshold language. The word points to a crossing space, not simply a spooky aesthetic. A liminal state matters because normal categories stop working for a while.

Why these examples belong together

The logic is cumulative. Liminality gives the section its first concrete anchor. Rites of passage complicates that anchor instead of leaving it alone. Identity thresholds pushes the same pressure into a wider human or civic problem.

That is why the examples should be read as a chain. Each one changes the scale, from personal feeling to systems, culture, design, politics, or memory.

Core concepts explained from zero

Concept	Definition from zero	Official anchor	Common trap
Liminality	Liminality is the condition of being between states, identities, or places.	It is neither fully one thing nor another, It can be social, emotional, architectural, or ritual	suspends stable categories; the person, place, or system is not simply before or after but between identities.
Liminal spaces in architecture	Some built spaces exist mainly to move people from one zone to another.	Examples include corridors, escalators, terminals, stairwells, waiting rooms, They are functional but often emotionally charged	makes transition physical: corridors, hotels, stations, and waiting rooms hold people without fully belonging to anyone.
The uncanny and familiar strangeness	Something can feel familiar and unsettling at the same time.	The uncanny often emerges from spaces that are known but depopulated or slightly wrong, Liminal spaces online became popular partly because of this emotional mix	makes ordinary spaces feel wrong by removing the social life that usually explains them.
Rites of passage	Many cultures mark transitions with rituals that place people in temporary in-between states.	A rite of passage often includes separation, liminality, and reintegration, The middle phase is unstable but important	Weak reading: turns transition into ceremony so a community can recognize that someone has crossed a threshold.
Liminal aesthetics online	Internet culture turned liminal imagery into a recognizable visual genre.	Images often feature empty, fluorescent, or transitional spaces, They combine nostalgia and discomfort	turns in-between spaces into a mood, making emptiness, transition, and almost-belonging shareable.
Identity thresholds	People can also be liminal when they are between roles, ages, or places.	Adolescence is a classic liminal stage, Migrants may feel between cultures	Weak reading: marks the moment when a person is treated as becoming something else before they fully feel changed.

Chapter 1 - What in-between really means

The idea

is the condition of being between states, identities, or places. It is neither fully one thing nor another. It can be social, emotional, architectural, or ritual. Liminal states are transitional but meaningful. They often produce ambiguity and heightened attention.

Suspends stable categories; the person, place, or system is not simply before or after but between identities. In-between states are powerful because they remove the old label before the new one fully holds.

The official WSC examples

It is neither fully one thing nor another. It can be social, emotional, architectural, or ritual. Liminal states are transitional but meaningful.

Why it matters

In-between states are powerful because they remove the old label before the new one fully holds.

Transfer cases

Airports at night: An airport after midnight feels between worlds: public but empty, lit but tired, functional but dreamlike.

Graduation: A ceremony holds people between identities. The graduate is no longer one thing and not yet settled into the next.

Chapter 2 - Architecture built for passing through

The idea

Some built spaces exist mainly to move people from one zone to another. Examples include corridors, escalators, terminals, stairwells, waiting rooms. They are functional but often emotionally charged. Their emptiness can feel eerie or peaceful. They remind people that movement is part of modern life.

It makes transition physical: corridors, hotels, stations, and waiting rooms hold people without fully belonging to anyone. Transit spaces feel strange because they are designed for passing through, not belonging.

The official WSC examples

The concrete details keep the idea from floating away. Examples include corridors, escalators, terminals, stairwells, waiting rooms. They are functional but often emotionally charged. Their emptiness can feel eerie or peaceful.

Why it matters

Transit spaces feel strange because they are designed for passing through, not belonging.

Transfer cases

Online liminal images: Empty malls and pools feel strange because they remove the human activity that normally explains them.

Airports at night: An airport after midnight feels between worlds: public but empty, lit but tired, functional but dreamlike.

Chapter 3 - The uncanny ordinary

The idea

Something can feel familiar and unsettling at the same time. The uncanny often emerges from spaces that are known but depopulated or slightly wrong. Liminal spaces online became popular partly because of this emotional mix. Stillness and emptiness can intensify attention. Mood depends on memory and expectation.

The section pairs this with Rites of passage: Many cultures mark transitions with rituals that place people in temporary in-between states. A rite of passage often includes separation, liminality, and reintegration. The middle phase is unstable but important. Graduation and initiation ceremonies often work this way. The journey changes identity, not just location.

It makes ordinary spaces feel wrong by removing the social life that usually explains them. The uncanny often begins when an ordinary place loses the people, purpose, or rhythm that usually makes it make sense.

The official WSC examples

This is where the official examples become useful. The uncanny often emerges from spaces that are known but depopulated or slightly wrong. Liminal spaces online became popular partly because of this emotional mix. Stillness and emptiness can intensify attention. A rite of passage often includes separation, liminality, and reintegration. The middle phase is unstable but important. Graduation and initiation ceremonies often work this way.

Why it matters

The uncanny often begins when an ordinary place loses the people, purpose, or rhythm that usually makes it make sense.

Transfer cases

Graduation: A ceremony holds people between identities. The graduate is no longer one thing and not yet settled into the next.

Online liminal images: Empty malls and pools feel strange because they remove the human activity that normally explains them.

Chapter 4 - Rites, thresholds, and unstable identities

The idea

Internet culture turned liminal imagery into a recognizable visual genre. Images often feature empty, fluorescent, or transitional spaces. They combine nostalgia and discomfort. The genre reflects anxiety about modern movement and belonging. It turns ordinary architecture into emotional symbolism.

It turns in-between spaces into a mood, making emptiness, transition, and almost-belonging shareable. Online liminal images turn architectural emptiness into shared emotional shorthand.

The official WSC examples

The small details are worth slowing down for. Images often feature empty, fluorescent, or transitional spaces. They combine nostalgia and discomfort. The genre reflects anxiety about modern movement and belonging.

Why it matters

Online liminal images turn architectural emptiness into shared emotional shorthand.

Transfer cases

Airports at night: An airport after midnight feels between worlds: public but empty, lit but tired, functional but dreamlike.

Graduation: A ceremony holds people between identities. The graduate is no longer one thing and not yet settled into the next.

Chapter 5 - Why the liminal can be lovely

The idea

People can also be liminal when they are between roles, ages, or places. Adolescence is a classic liminal stage. Migrants may feel between cultures. Recovery can create an unstable in-between identity. Threshold states can be freeing and frightening.

Marks the moment when a person is treated as becoming something else before they fully feel changed. Identity change is rarely instant. People often get treated as new before they feel new.

The official WSC examples

Adolescence is a classic liminal stage. Migrants may feel between cultures. Recovery can create an unstable in-between identity.

Why it matters

Identity change is rarely instant. People often get treated as new before they feel new.

Transfer cases

Online liminal images: Empty malls and pools feel strange because they remove the human activity that normally explains them.

Airports at night: An airport after midnight feels between worlds: public but empty, lit but tired, functional but dreamlike.

Transfer table - examples that fit the same logic

Logic to extend	Official anchor	Nearby WSC connection	Outside example	Why it fits
In-between states have their beauty.	Liminal spaces, thresholds,	Introductory Questions, Going Home and Wandering.	A train platform at night when the train has arrived and nobody fully knows where they are.	The power is the suspended state, not the final destination.
A threshold is both place and process.	Liminal architecture and environment in transition.	Sidewalks, airports, borders, and graduation ceremonies.	A hospital waiting room before a doctor's appointment or changing results.	The room matters because it's a place where people are between before and after.
Rites of passage organize liminality.	Transition from one status to another.	Going Pains, adolescence, graduation, citizenship.	A quinceañera, bar/bat mitzvah, or graduation ceremony.	Ceremony gives a social shape to an otherwise unstable transition.
Too much liminality becomes unsettling.	The lovely vs the unsettling.	Stuck airports, refugees, and long-term projects.	Someone waiting months for a visa or status without knowing when they will get it or if they are home.	The in-between can be a place of hope or becomes a trapped life.
Empty spaces can reveal value through use.	Liminal photography/aesthetics.	Drafts, ruins, apocalyptic art.	An abandoned shopping mall or a room photographed after closing.	The beauty comes from a place that is still carrying traces of movement and no longer performs its old function.
Digital liminality feels endless.	Online waiting, loading, fees, and avatars.	Progress bars, futurism, and online games.	A profile setup screen where you are not yet complete.	The user exists in a pre-arrival state inside the interface.
Borders produce liminal people.	Transit and thresholds.	Call of Duty-Free, Home and Wandering, passports.	A person in asylum process who is physically present but legally unresolved.	The state of arrival depends on legal recognition, not just location.
Liminal beauty can be sold.	Aestheticized thresholds.	Tourism, duty-free zones, and travel.	Hotels that market "escape" or "luxury" offering standardized space everywhere.	The in-between becomes a product once the atmosphere is packaged and sold.

8. Final synthesis

The big tensions

Is liminality a place or a feeling?

Why do empty transition spaces feel uncanny?

Why are people drawn to eerie familiarity?

Why do societies ritualize transitions?

Why did liminal spaces become so shareable online?

Are liminal identities more vulnerable or more open?

How the examples connect

The Lovely and the Liminal works because its examples share a pressure even when their surfaces differ. The surface examples give alpacas memory hooks. The deeper pattern shows what is being measured, who controls the route, what remains unfinished, and what kind of arrival is being promised.

The transfer cases make this clearer: Airports at night, Graduation, Online liminal images. Each one helps move the section beyond the official examples without replacing them.

Pitfalls to avoid

Mistaking the visible object for the whole idea.

Treating a measurement as neutral when it defines value.

Calling movement progress before checking who benefits.

Ignoring what the route excludes, delays, or hides.

Assuming an ending is settled because someone has declared it.

What alpacas should remember

The liminal is where categories loosen before a new form settles. Keep the examples concrete. The analysis becomes stronger when alpacas can explain what each example does, not only what it is.